continuation of his manner of succession, where he settled matters to his own satisfaction, as he had settled the question of succession, with violence.

Ashoka's assumption of the throne is in the *Ashokavadana* immediately followed by an orgy of state-sponsored terror. A chapter title 'Chandashoka', which can be translated as 'Ashoka the fierce', graphically spells out the new king's cruelty and killings.[1] The first episode of his reign discussed in some detail concerns various ministers who were put to death by him. The clique from Bindusara's time which had helped Ashoka become king had now apparently begun treating him with contempt. To test their loyalty Ashoka ordered that they chop down every flowering and fruiting tree while preserving those that were thorny. On the face of it, the order seems absurd (quite apart from the taxonomic stupidity: trees that have thorns often bear flowers and fruit). But, as Tennyson might have put it, this was a bad case of 'Theirs not to make reply,/ Theirs not to reason why,/ Theirs but to do and die': the criterion for establishing loyalty to this monarch rested not on questioning the king's command, however absurd it sounded, but in just blindly obeying it. His ministers were not loyal enough, for, despite being repeated three times, the order was not carried out. Consequently, Ashoka is said to have personally cut off the heads of 'five hundred' of them.

The story is reminiscent of the secret tests that the *Arthashastra* prescribed for kings to test the integrity or lack of it in ministers. Such officials were to be instigated through secret agents to go against the king. This was done by the agents suggesting to them that the king was impious, and that they should 'set up another pious (king), either a claimant from his own family or a prince in disfavour or a member of the (royal) family or a person who is the one support of the kingdom or a neighbouring prince or a forest chieftain or a person suddenly risen to power.'[2] If the instigation was repulsed, the minister was said to be loyal. To judge from the statecraft prescribed for rulers in Mauryan times, this aspect of the *Ashokavadana's*